Reading through Indian University Politics

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Introduction

The cry *"Azadi"* took on a completely different meaning after it echoed across a campus that was on the precipice of changing Indian politics forever. Kanhaiya Kumar's impassioned address upon his release from incarceration—following allegations of sedition for an incident in which he had not participated—resonated with the sentiments of a restless youth constituency. *"Azadi"* represented the awakening of a populace to a long-standing hallucination, exposing the dissonance between the democratic ideals enshrined in the nation's founding vision and the material realities of exclusion and subjugation. The sheer simplicity of the word *"Azadi"* allowed a wide spectrum of movements to co-opt it, including the very right-wing movement it had originally been a cry against. As Rajarshi Dasgupta (2017) observes, the slogan formed "a long train of thought running from Kashmir to Hyderabad, from feminist activism in urban spaces to the constitutional legacy of Ambedkar," aligning disparate struggles in a plural, intertextual constellation. Analyzing the corpus of a political movement's language provides critical insight into the relationship between linguistic structure and political power, as the chosen terminology explicitly or implicitly manifests its fundamental priorities, biases, and internal distribution of authority.

Within this milieu, the public university functions as a very unique political actor within a democratic, secular, and diverse state. In the context of contemporary India, the public university serves as a locus of convergence for various social groups across caste, class, religion, and gender. Its structure fosters encounters of plurality that can mediate hierarchies and cultivate democratic participation. It is also understood that the public university becomes a special space of protest as it congregates youth at a formative stage of identity development, a period marked by openness to radical ideologies, which find fertile ground in the scholarly, socially engaged, and often oppositional campus environment. Deshpande (2016) argues that the public university constitutes "a historically unprecedented space" in the democratization of Indian society, and for that very reason, has increasingly come to be perceived as a site of ideological threat by dominant social and political institutions.

However, the neoliberal restructuring of Indian education has repositioned the university within a markedly different ideological framework. As Jaiswal (2018) contends, the transition from viewing education as a "public, social good" to treating it as a "private, profitable commodity" has engendered a profound transformation in the university's purpose and ethos. This commodification of education has had many consequences for the idea of the university. Education has become market-oriented, and its goals have shifted from building an intellectually

charged citizenry to producing a ready-made labour force that is servile to the capitalist state and corporate establishment. This has led to a growing disdain for the humanities, within universities and among public sentiment, which don't provide anything valuable within the neoliberal framework of capitalism. This privat ization of educational institutions has resulted in a new type of political socialization of its students, owing to its different demographic constitutions, its corporate objectives, and structures of administration.

This research seeks to examine these ideological and linguistic divergences through a comparative analysis of political lexicons across public and private universities. Drawing on John Thomas Martelli's Diversity, Democracy, and Dissent as a corpus for JNU's politics, and employing a computational text analysis of articles scraped from Ashoka University's digital publications, the study aims to contrast the political language, discursive structures, and thematic concerns prevalent in the two institutional contexts. Through this comparative approach, the paper investigates how privatization reshapes democratic discourse and alters the contours of political socialization within the Indian university.

Background

Ashoka University and Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) represent two contrasting yet influential models in the landscape of Indian higher education, each marked by distinctive histories and political engagements. Their comparison offers a robust framework for analyzing how institutional structure and ethos shape student politics and political socialization.

Ashoka University was established in 2014 as a private, liberal arts university in Sonipat, Haryana, inspired by global standards and spearheaded by philanthropic founders from diverse professional backgrounds. While its curriculum sought to foster debate and inclusiveness, the campus's political climate has historically been characterized more by cautious engagement than mass mobilization. Recent years have witnessed sporadic student activism, notably around demands for greater inclusion—such as calls for a caste census and advocacy on issues beyond the campus—yet these efforts are frequently described as less vigorous or confrontational than those of older public institutions. Analysts attribute this to Ashoka's privileged demographic makeup and evolving but individualistic campus culture, which can sometimes blunt collective political engagement.

Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), founded by an Act of Parliament in 1969, is widely regarded as the epicenter of student political activity in India. Conceived as a public institution committed to social justice, JNU was designed to serve students from a broad range of socio-economic backgrounds and quickly developed a reputation for its vibrant intellectual and activist culture.

The university is synonymous with open-air debates, protests, and a politicized student body actively engaged with national issues—a culture bolstered by a tradition of student self-governance and contentious but inclusive elections. JNU student organizations and movements have frequently influenced, and even spearheaded, broader social justice agitations—from historic protests after the murder of Chandrasekhar Prasad to recent mobilizations like Occupy UGC, Rohith Vemula, and anti-CAA demonstrations. The public character of JNU, with its legally protected status and legacy of democratizing access, further nurtures a campus where dissent and counter-narratives are both expected and institutionally safeguarded.

These institutions make for an instructive comparison. Ashoka's emergence as an elite private university with global aspirations and JNU's deeply-rooted public ethos highlight how structural contexts—public versus private, open versus selective—shape both the forms of student politics and the languages through which political engagement is articulated. Where JNU's inclusiveness and traditional commitment to activism have made it a crucible for democratic dissent, Ashoka's evolving experiment offers insight into the neoliberal turn in Indian higher education and its effects on youth political agency.

Methodology

This study employs a comparative textual analysis to understand how institutional contexts—public versus private, open versus selective—shape both the forms of student politics and the languages used to articulate political engagement. The analysis draws on two distinct corpora representing each university's political discourse.

Data Collection

For JNU, the study utilizes the data and methods from John Thomas Martelli's research, "Democracy, Diversity, and Dissent". Martelli analyzes a large collection of student organization pamphlets using lexicometric tools, tracing thematic and lexical shifts over time and mapping the lexicon associated with different political organizations on campus. These pamphlets, curated in the "Pamphlet Repository for Changing Activism (PaRChA)," form the basis for the JNU corpus.

To compare with the existing corpus, we created a new corpus comprising 116 articles from "The Edict," Ashoka University's independent student newspaper. This material was drawn from the publication's digital archives, spanning both the politics and opinion sections from 2016 to 2025. This diverse sample aims to capture shifts and continuities in political language as shaped by events, campus culture, and the selective, privately governed institutional environment.

Analytical Approach

Following Martelli's approach, both corpora—JNU pamphlets and Ashoka articles—will undergo clustering and association analysis to uncover word clusters and their semantic relationships. The methodology involves examining and comparing the distinct patterns of word usage and topic grouping in two separate sets of political texts to reveal differences shaped by institutional and cultural contexts, using natural language clustering techniques.

The comparative framework thus relates changes in word associations and thematic clusters to the distinct structural contexts: the highly public, politically plural, and oppositional culture of JNU versus the selective, privatized, and administratively mediated campus politics of Ashoka University.

Considerations

Posters and long-form articles fundamentally differ in their function, authorship, and circulation on university campuses. Posters operate as immediate calls to action, often mobilizing students around specific issues or events (Taras, 2015). Their formats encourage collective authorship—a poster might be attributed to a student organization rather than an individual, allowing the message to circulate without placing direct responsibility or risk on any single person (Carlson, 2011). This anonymity can foster bolder, more radical expressions of dissent, as individuals are shielded from administrative or social repercussions. In contrast, long-form articles in official university newspapers, such as Ashoka University's "The Edict," require named authorship and often pass through editorial review. This makes the writer directly accessible and traceable, introducing a higher threshold for voicing controversial or extreme opinions (Broersma, 2010). Despite these differences—which entail separate audience reach, time frames, and modes of activism—comparing posters and longform articles remains analytically valuable. Both genres reflect distinct but complementary modalities of political communication shaped by their institutional settings: posters embody public, urgent mobilization, while articles record sustained reflection and negotiation within the university's formal media sphere (Lievrouw, 2011).

Research Findings

A quantitative analysis of the Ashoka University corpus (2016–2025) reveals that the most frequently occurring words are "students" (frequency = 623) and "student" (frequency = 622), followed by "Ashoka" (frequency = 554) and "university" (frequency = 367). Notably, specific struggles related to social categories such as caste, class, gender, or race are absent from the top 25 most frequent words.

The word “workers” appears 181 times, highlighting a persistent Marxist orientation and reflecting Ashoka students’ historical engagement in labor rights activism, including protests advocating for the workers on campus. This engagement is notably visible in recent events, such as the 2025 strike by housekeeping staff demanding fair wages and humane working conditions. During this protest, students joined workers outside the university gates in solidarity, amplifying the call for justice and opposing attempts by the administration to pressure or intimidate protestors.

Figure 1(a): High associations of co-occurring words to the word worker

Figure 1(b): High associations of co-occurring words to the word dalit

Figure 1(c): High associations of co-occurring words to the word caste

The term “dalit” registers zero occurrences in the corpus. Analysis of terms most semantically similar to “dalit” reveals them to be upper-caste (often Brahmin) surnames, rather than references to marginalized caste groups. This absence is particularly significant, and even the 23 mentions of “caste” are noteworthy for being associated with the term “casteless” among their most similar words. There is a conspicuous silence on caste-based scholarships, with no mention of such programs in Ashoka’s official “Inclusion and Diversity Report 2023-2024”. Based on the submitted institute data for NIRF 2025, the combined population of socially backward classes, which includes SC, ST, and OBCs, is less than 6% of the student population in Ashoka University. The Social Justice Forum (SJF) at Ashoka University, a student body that advocates for the rights of minority groups, initiated protests beginning March 20, 2024, demanding the implementation of an annual caste-based census inclusive of students, faculty, and staff, citing underrepresentation of marginalized castes. The Vice Chancellor responded by affirming the university's commitment to establishing grievance redressal and equal opportunity cells, but stated that the caste census demand would require further discussion with stakeholders and did not approve it outright.

Figure 1(d): High associations of co-occurring words to the word "feminism"

While the term "feminism" occurs directly only once, related terms—such as "feminists" (10), "gender" (43), "female" (24), and "women" (96)—indicate robust engagement with gender and sexuality themes. The 2025 student union elections reinforces this idea, with both the president and vice president, elected from the United Students Front (USF), the dominant left-wing student organization on campus, being women. Institutionally, visible initiatives such as the Ashoka University Queer Collective and the Feminist Collective have fostered sustained dialogue on gender diversity and inclusion. The female-to-male students ratio is an impressive 1.4, based on the submitted institute data for NIRF 2025, which points to healthy gender diversity on the campus.

Figure 1(e): High associations of co-occurring words to the word radical

The word "radical" appears only 8 times in the corpus. The words most closely associated with "radical" tend to be non-specific and general in nature, lacking clear or consistent political or

ideological context. This suggests that the term is used sparingly and without a strong emphasis on particular ideas or movements within the student discourse at Ashoka University.

Comparative Analysis

Antonio Gramsci introduced the concept of "organic intellectuals" to describe individuals who emerge from within a social class and play a crucial role in shaping its ideology, culture, and political consciousness. Organic intellectuals are not detached from the masses but are organically linked to them, articulating the experiences and aspirations of their class and helping to organize and mobilize it for political action. This idea of the organic individual can be used as a framework to disseminate JNU's politics. JNU's reservation policy includes 27% seats reserved for OBCs, 15% for SCs, 7.5% for STs, and 5% for persons with disabilities, in accordance with the Government of India's reservation policy. From within these promised populations of minorities, "organic intellectuals" arise. Gramsci emphasizes the pivotal role of organic intellectuals in challenging the hegemony of the dominant group and building a counter-hegemonic bloc, seeing them as essential actors who have the ability to mobilise their social class to revolt. We see these counter-hegemonic blocs prevalent in JNU, in the form of the United Dalit Students' Forum(UDSF), Bahujan Students' Forum(BSF), and Birsa Ambedkar Phule Students' Association(BAPSA), who assimilate the vocabulary of struggle within their specific goal of caste emancipation. Entities like the Democratic Student Union(DSU) and the All India Students' Association(AISA), recalibrate the meaning of "struggle" with Naxalbari, peasant, Kashmir, feudalism, and Telangana, focusing on external interpretations of radicalisation. The Students' Federation of India(SFI) and the Democratic Students' Federation(DSF) focus on campus-related struggles of students, addressing more in-situ matters. This plurality of political thought exists because JNU accommodates the lived realities of myriad marginalizations across the country, which marinate a far-ranging and heterogeneous political lexicon. Mobilization occurs when such "organic intellectuals" arise for different social groups, concentrating these lived realities into actionable units. When your peer group, your classmates, and your neighbours face different kinds of marginalization, the empathy generated transcribes to a widening of your political dictionary.

Gramsci defines "traditional intellectuals" as those who see themselves as autonomous and independent from social classes, but in reality, are aligned with and serve the interests of the dominant class by legitimizing the existing power structures and values. These intellectuals typically belong to established institutions such as the clergy, professors, and scholars, and sustain the prevailing cultural and ideological framework rather than challenging it. This is representative of Ashoka's majorly elite populace, both economically and socially, given the lack of reservations during admission. Private universities like Ashoka, under the veil of meritocracy, tend to homogenize their diaspora of students. Ashoka invites a youth that is mostly informed by

Western, liberal values; these being more proximate to their lived realities. An easy dodge would be to jump on the bandwagon of admonishing this upper-class Gen Z for their *"performative activism"* and *"social media virtue signalling",* without systemically analyzing the structures that actualize these occurrences. This prevalence of "traditional intellectuals" is a consequence of the indistinguishable community they live within. Concern for issues that are otherwise distant to a student is only created when uncomfortable conversation and diverse community is encouraged within the campus. The political socialization of a student is a reflection of their immediate community, which takes the role of generating empathy for issues that are distant and unrelatable. Students in private universities are placed in vacuums, shielded from other socioeconomic groups, where communities become self-facing because the self and the community care about the same issues. In a campus that is homogeneous, concerns overlap, and political vocabulary converges. Private universities operate in the perennial fear of student radicalisation, which increases with a diverse and more marginalised populace. When the SJF in Ashoka demanded for an annual lecture series titled 'Ambedkar Memorial Lecture', the Vice Chancellor could not promise it would be titled the Ambedkar Memorial Lecture, and that it would be left to the faculty members to decide. This exemplifies the terror of radical politics within private institutions, where priorities don't align with an enraged student body that can declassify and attack their neoliberal policies. Private liberal arts universities, such as Ashoka, aim to "foster critical thought", insofar as it generates brilliant phd scholars and academic work that can rival international standards, without it ever becoming radical. They incubate multiple "traditional intellectuals", without really focusing on enhancing a more rounded political socialization. This is reflected in the lack of radical vocabulary within the Ashokan political landscape, where the priority is to generate erudite political commentators who are not political.

Conclusion

The private university is always going to be at odds with marginalised communities. Making space for them directly causes a dent in its capitalist motives, concealed carefully under the value system of merit, which is automatically palatable to the urban elite. By neglecting the social, economic, and urban capital they have accrued over time and space, the urban elite deludes itself into believing it deserves everything it receives. Within such contexts, it becomes nearly impossible to create a student body that is politically socialized to the vast majority of vulnerabilities within India. Their language is restricted to problems they face on campus and that of the Western liberal canon, which is made aspirational through their socialization. It's as simple as being a Marxist without understanding its intersection with caste in the context of India. This is not to say that a private liberal arts university is bound to be elitist. In fact, within the current political climate where communalism is rampant and dissent is almost criminal, they might just be our only respite to revive secular and democratic ideologies. A private university formed for the objective of disseminating the democratic spirit and fostering critical thought,

without an ulterior motive such as profit, might allow the reparation of a disillusioned populace. A university like Tagore's Shantiniketan, where the goal is to develop critical minds that are empathetic to those around them. JNU explains how community plays a large role in political socialization, breaking the vacuums of childhood to allow space for issues other than those you face. It is with this ethos of community-driven empathy that a citizenry can co-opt a multitude of issues and formulate an expansive political vocabulary. In times like these, when social fabrics are breaking and society is transforming, we need this focus on community more than ever.

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